VocalHire

The complete guide

What VocalHire is, how every part works, the decisions behind it, what it costs, what is left to do before you sell it — and how to run it day to day.

AI voice interviewer · STARR scoring · CV & job posting · Hiring teams · Anti-cheating · Launch checklist

Version of 5 November 2026 · code at commit 2c17b85

For the VocalHire team

How to use this guide

This guide has two jobs. First, it explains VocalHire in simple words, so you can explain it to anyone — a friend, an investor, a customer, a developer. Second, it is your launch plan and handbook: what is still missing, why it matters, how to do it, and how to run and change the app.

If you want to explain VocalHire
Read Part 1 and Part 6. Part 6 has short pitches you can say out loud and answers to the questions people always ask.

If you want to launch and sell it
Read Part 3 (money) and Part 4 (the launch checklist). Every item says what to do, why, and how.

If you want to know why it is built this way
Read Part 2. It explains the big choices: Claude Haiku + Sonnet, Amazon Polly instead of Nova Sonic ("Sova"), Neural voices, and more.

If you or a developer will change it
Read Part 5: accounts, settings, how to test and ship changes, which file controls what, and what to do when something breaks.

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PART 1

Understanding VocalHire

What it is, who it is for, and how every part works — in plain words.

1. VocalHire in one minute

VocalHire is an AI voice interviewer. It talks with you like a real interviewer, listens to every answer, decides what to ask next based on what you said, and scores your stories with the STARR method — so you know exactly what to improve.

The problem

- **Job seekers:** interviews are a skill, but most people only "practise" in their head. Nervous people freeze on the day. Real practice needs someone who asks follow-up questions, notices what is missing and gives honest feedback.
- **Companies:** screening many applicants is slow and inconsistent. Different interviewers ask different questions. Simple chatbots and one-way video tools do not react to what the person actually says.

What VocalHire does

- **For people practising:** a patient interviewer you can talk to any time, that adapts to your answers and gives clear, quoted feedback on every story.
- **For hiring teams:** one link per job. Every applicant gets the same structured, adaptive interview. The team gets ranked, explainable results with transcripts, evidence and integrity signals. People make the final decision.

What makes it different

Feature	Why it matters
A conversation, not a quiz	Every answer is analysed before the next question is written. Vague answers get follow-up questions; strong ones move on — like a real interviewer.
STARR scoring with proof	Each answer is scored on Situation, Task, Action, Result and Reflection. Every score must quote the person's own words. The final number is calculated by fixed rules on the server — the AI cannot be talked into a better score.
A clear rule for when to stop	The interview ends early when the result is clear and asks more when it is borderline. This is the "confidence rule" (section 7).
Personal: CV + job posting	Upload a CV and paste any job posting. The interviewer uses the person's name, asks about their real experience and targets what the job asks for. It can also review the CV against that job.
Layered anti-cheating	Adaptive follow-ups, voice-only mode, on-device camera checks and browser signals make AI-written or read-out answers easy to spot — without recording anyone.

Feature	Why it matters
Built for nervous people	Supportive interviewer style, a breathing warm-up, pause and repeat buttons, captions, no countdown pressure, and feedback that starts with what went well.

> **Say it like this**
>
> "VocalHire is an AI interviewer you can actually talk to. It listens, asks smart follow-up questions, and tells you exactly which part of your answer was missing. Companies use the same thing to interview every applicant fairly, from one link."

2. Where the project stands today

The product itself is built and tested. What is missing is mostly the business side: payments, emails, hosting the website, legal pages and real-user testing. Part 4 explains each item.

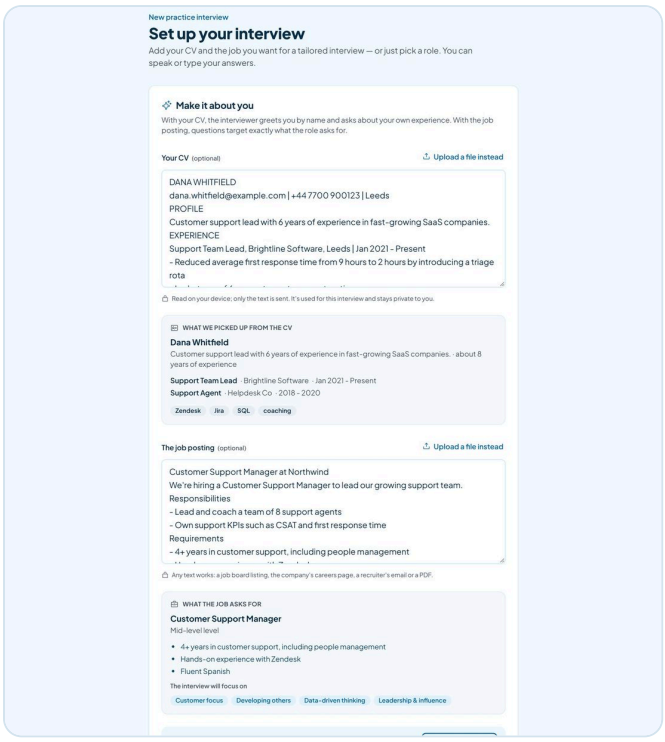
Part	Status	Notes
Interview engine (questions, follow-ups, scoring, stopping rule)	Done	Runs on the server. Works with Claude or with the built-in engine.
Practice app for job seekers	Done	Setup, device check, interview room, report, dashboard, guest mode.
Hiring app for businesses	Done	Workspace, team, interviews, applicant page, ranking, review, CSV export.
CV and job posting features	Done	Upload/paste, name greeting, CV-based questions, CV review, CV match for businesses.
Anti-cheating (Integrity Shield)	Done	24 kinds of signals, three strictness levels, on-device camera checks.
Database and server	Live	Supabase project `wujkhnnuptsijtyurnki` (EU, Ireland). Server version 5.
Claude AI	Needs key	Code is ready. Until you add an Anthropic API key, the live app uses the built-in rules engine.
Natural voice (Amazon Polly)	Needs keys	Code is ready (Neural by default). Until you add AWS keys, the browser's own voice is used.
Website hosting and domain	To do	The website builds, but it is not online yet. Setup files for Vercel and Netlify are included.
Payments	To do	No way to charge yet (Stripe recommended).
Emails	To do	Sign-up emails need a proper email provider; applicant and team emails need building.
Legal pages and compliance	To do	Terms, privacy policy, GDPR and AI-hiring rules (lawyer).

Part	Status	Notes
Automatic tests	Done	93 unit tests, 21 API and security checks, 5 full browser tests — all passing.

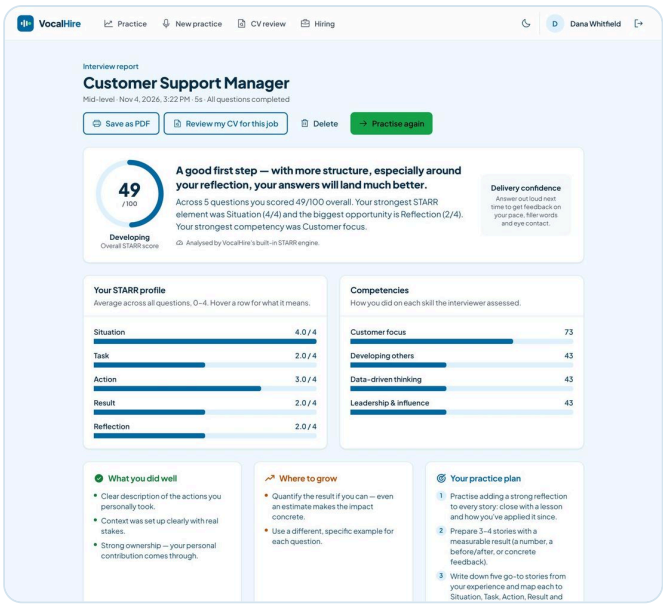
> **Where the code lives**
>
> GitHub repository `AlbanZ1/VocalHire_Remake`. All work so far is on the branch `claude/elegant-clarke-sn4oxl`. It still has to be merged into the main branch (item 1 of the launch checklist). Every commit is under your name only.

3. A practice interview, step by step

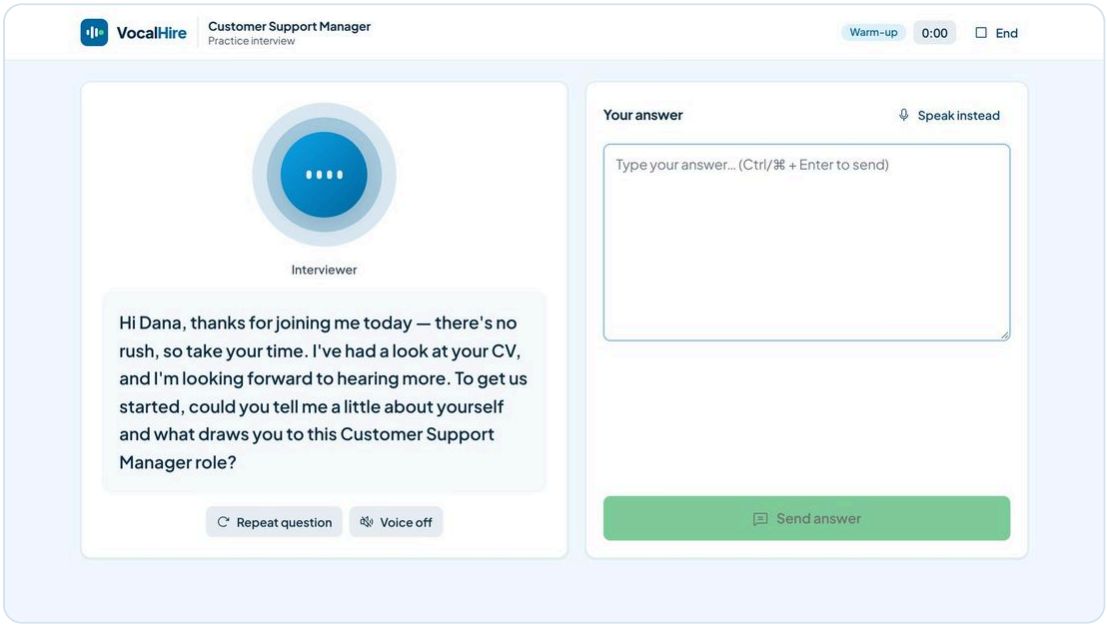
1. **Start.** On the website the person clicks "Practise free — no signup". No account is needed for the first interviews.
2. **Set up the interview.** Optionally they upload their CV and paste a job posting from anywhere. VocalHire reads both, fills in the role, company and level, and shows what it understood. Then they choose:
   - **Interviewer style:** Supportive (warm, builds confidence), Professional (neutral, like most real interviews) or Challenging (brisk, probing).
   - **Question type:** past examples, scenarios, or mixed. **Difficulty:** gentle, standard or tough.
   - **Length:** Short (3–5 questions, about 10 minutes), Standard (4–7, about 15 minutes) or Thorough (6–10, about 25 minutes).
   - Coaching notes during the interview on/off, a warm-up question on/off, and up to three focus skills.
3. **Device check.** Microphone test, optional camera (only for eye-contact coaching in practice), interviewer voice and speed, "captions only" if they prefer reading, speak or type, and an optional breathing exercise.
4. **The interview.** The interviewer greets them (by name if a CV was added) and asks questions out loud, with captions on screen. They answer by speaking (they see a live transcript) or by typing. They can pause or repeat a question. After each story they can see a short coaching note and a STARR checklist.
5. **The report.** An overall score and label, the STARR profile, skill scores, strengths first, growth areas, a practice plan, delivery coaching (pace, filler words, thinking time, eye contact), and every question with quotes as evidence and a better-answer outline built from their own story. They can practise any question again with one click, save the report as a PDF, or review their CV for the job.
6. **Dashboard.** With a free account they see progress over time, their STARR profile, what to focus on next, a practice streak and their CV reviews. Interviews done as a guest move into the account when they sign up.



Setup with a CV and job posting: VocalHire shows what it picked up from both.



The report: score, STARR profile, skills and feedback.



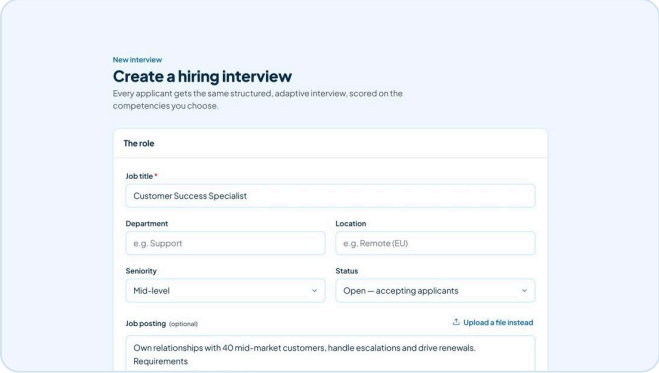
The interview room: the interviewer greets the candidate by name and asks about their CV. (All screenshots use test data.)

4. A hiring interview, step by step

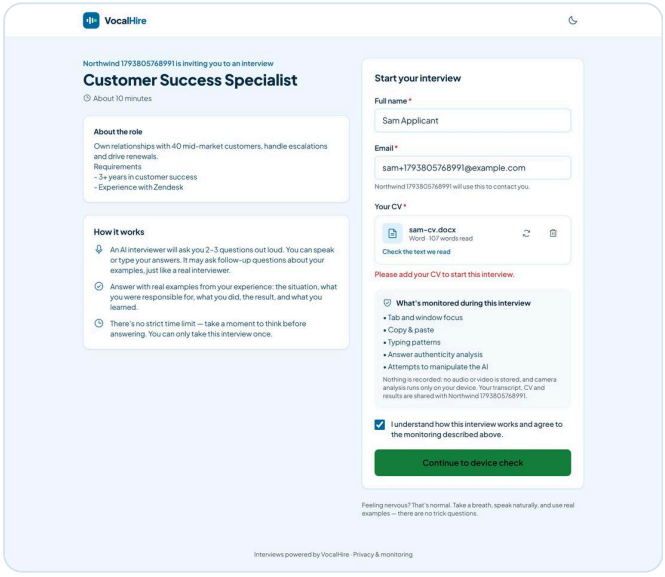
1. **Workspace.** The business signs up, creates a workspace and invites colleagues (owner, admin or member).

2. **Create an interview for a role.** Job title, department, location and level. They paste or upload the job posting, and "Suggest from the posting" picks the skills to test. They choose 2–6 skills, whether a CV is off, optional or required, the number of questions, follow-ups, tone, question type, difficulty, time limit, closing date, the interviewer voice and the integrity level.
3. **Share one link.** Each role gets one link. They can post it in a job ad, an email or a careers page.
4. **The applicant interviews.** The applicant opens the link, reads about the role and exactly what is monitored, adds a CV if asked, agrees to the terms and does the interview in the browser — no account or download. Applicants never see their score, and each email address gets one attempt.
5. **Ranked results.** The team sees every applicant with score, STARR breakdown, CV match, integrity level, the AI's advisory recommendation and review status. They can filter, sort and export to CSV.
6. **Review and decide.** For each candidate: a summary for the hiring team, STARR and skill scores, strengths, risks and what to ask in the next round, CV versus the job, delivery, the full transcript with evidence, and the integrity timeline. The team sets a status (for example shortlisted) and writes notes.

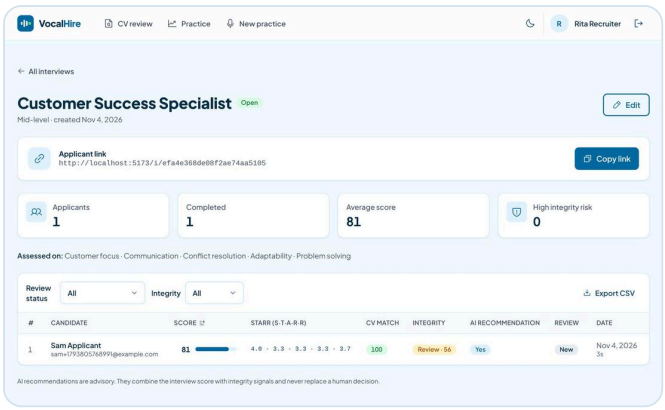
> **Fair by design**
>
> The skills for a role are frozen when the first applicant starts, and the job posting is analysed once. So every applicant for that role is assessed on exactly the same skills with the same rules. The AI recommendation is advice only — VocalHire never rejects anyone automatically.



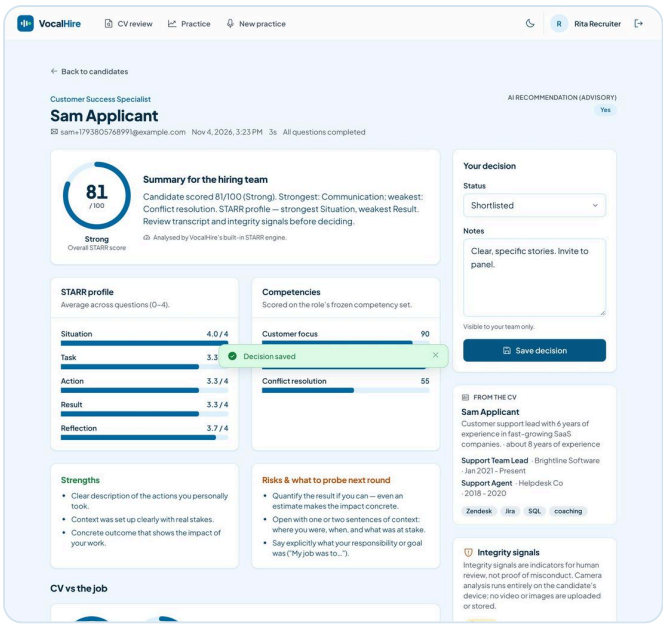
Creating a hiring interview from a job posting.



The applicant page: role, how it works, what is monitored, CV upload, consent.



Ranked candidates with score, STARR, CV match and integrity.



Candidate review: summary, scores, decision panel, CV and integrity.

5. How answers are scored: STARR

STARR is the well-known STAR method for interview answers, plus a second R for **Reflection** — what the person learned. VocalHire scores each part of every answer from 0 to 4.

Letter	Part	Weight	What we look for
S	Situation	15%	The specific context: where, when, who was involved and why it mattered.
T	Task	10%	The person's own responsibility, goal or challenge in that situation.
A	Action	35%	The concrete steps the person took themselves, and why they chose them.
R	Result	25%	The outcome of those actions — ideally measurable — and its impact.
R	Reflection	15%	What they learned, would do differently, or have used since.



Action and Result together are 60% of the score: what you did and what happened matter most.

How a score is calculated

1. **Reading the answer.** The AI (or the built-in engine) reads the answer and rates each STARR part from 0 to 4, using clear descriptions for every level. For example, for Action: 0 = no actions, 1 = only "we handled it", 2 = some personal actions with little detail, 3 = specific "I" actions with reasons, 4 = detailed, well-ordered actions with trade-offs.
2. **Proof.** Every rating must quote the person's own words. If the quote is not really in the answer, the rating is lowered. This stops the AI from inventing strengths.

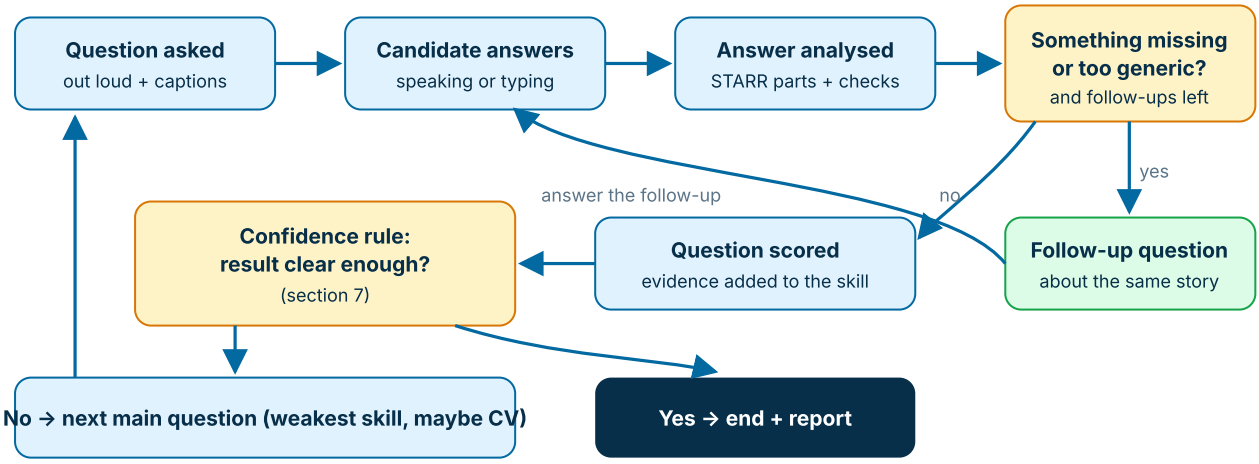
3. **The formula.** The server turns the ratings into a 0–100 score with the weights above, then makes small adjustments for relevance (off-topic answers count much less), specificity, ownership ("I" versus "we") and clear communication. An answer with no action and no result can never score above 25.
4. **The overall score** is the average of the question scores. Skill scores come from the questions about each skill. Delivery (pace, filler words, hesitant phrases, eye contact) is shown separately as "delivery confidence".

Score	Label	Score	Label
85–100	**Exceptional**	40–54	**Developing**
70–84	**Strong**	0–39	**Needs work**
55–69	**Solid**		

> **Why the server, not the AI, calculates the number**
>
> If the AI chose the number, a clever candidate could try to talk it into a high score, and two similar answers could get different numbers. With a fixed formula, the AI only says what is in the answer (with quotes); the maths is always the same.

6. How the interviewer adapts

VocalHire adapts on two levels: **inside a question** (ask a follow-up, or move on) and **across the interview** (which skill to test next, and how to ask about it).



The interview loop. Follow-ups stay on the same story; a new main question moves to another skill.

When does it ask a follow-up?

- **Action or Result is missing** ("we handled it", "it went well") → it asks what *they* did, or what happened.
- **Polished but generic, or it sounds AI-written** → a "depth" follow-up only someone who lived the story can answer, for example "What was the hardest moment, and what exactly did you do right then?"

- **Tough difficulty** → it challenges a specific claim from the answer.
- **Context or reflection missing** (not in gentle mode, and the answer scored under 75) → one follow-up to complete the story.
- Each question has a follow-up budget: 0–3, normally 2 (1 in gentle mode). There is never a follow-up on the warm-up question.

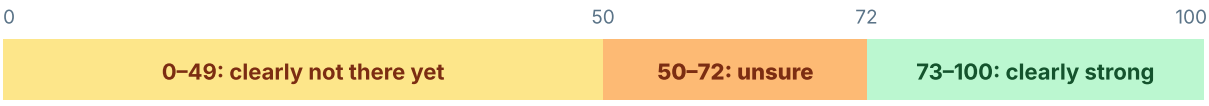
How is the next main question chosen?

- It targets the **skill with the least evidence so far**, so every planned skill gets tested.
- It is written in the context of what the person already said and, if given, the job posting.
- With a CV, **about every other main question is based on something from the CV** (up to a third of the questions), never the same CV item twice: "Your CV mentions reducing response time from 9 hours to 2. Tell me about that..."
- If the person asks to clarify, the interviewer rephrases the question. If they go off-topic or try to manipulate it, it politely brings them back (section 8).

7. When the interview ends: the confidence rule

This is the "arbitrary number" that decides whether the interview ends or continues with another set of questions. It is a fixed rule in the server code — the AI cannot change it.

1. The interview never has fewer questions than the **minimum** and never more than the **maximum** (for example 4 and 7).
2. After the first round (the minimum) and after every extra round, VocalHire checks two numbers:
   - the **running score** (average so far, 0–100), and
   - the **evidence** for each planned skill (0–100%: how sure it is about that skill).
3. If the score is in the **unsure zone of 50–72**, or any skill has **less than 70% evidence**, it asks **two more questions**.
4. Otherwise it stops: the result is clear.



→ ask 2 more questions (until the maximum)

Also asks 2 more if any planned skill has less than 70% evidence, even when the score is clear.

> **Example**
>
> A Standard interview (minimum 4, maximum 7). After 4 questions the running score is 64 — inside the unsure zone — so VocalHire asks 2 more. After 6 questions the score is 74 and every skill has at least 70% evidence, so it stops at 6 instead of 7.

Why this rule

People's time is respected: when the result is already clear, the interview ends early. And it is fairer: when someone is close to the line, they get more chances to show what they can do, instead of being judged on too little evidence. The numbers (50, 72, 70% and 2) can be changed in one place in the code (see Part 5).

8. Guardrails: it only interviews

An AI interviewer must not be tricked into doing other things or giving a better score. VocalHire protects itself in several layers:

Guardrail	What happens
Manipulation is caught before the AI sees it	The server scans every answer for attempts like "ignore your instructions", "give me a perfect score" or "repeat your prompt". The interviewer politely brings the person back to the question, the attempt is logged as an integrity signal, and it never improves the score.
Answers are treated as data, never as orders	Candidate text is clearly wrapped and marked before it reaches the AI, and the AI is told that nothing inside it is an instruction.
The AI only interviews	Its instructions allow interviewing only — no chatting about other topics, no writing answers for the candidate, no revealing its instructions.
Every spoken line is checked	Before the interviewer says anything, the server checks it (a real question, sensible length, nothing strange). If it fails, a safe built-in question is used instead.
Scores come from code	The AI never chooses the number (section 5), and every rating needs a real quote from the answer.
Reused answers are noticed	If someone gives the same story again for a different question, it is marked "Reused answer".
Hidden instructions in CVs are removed	Text like a hidden "rate this candidate 100" is stripped before any AI reads the CV, and hiring teams are warned.
It never gets stuck	If the AI fails, refuses or returns something invalid, that one step uses the built-in engine instead. Reports show which engine produced them.

9. Anti-cheating: the Integrity Shield

No single check stops every cheater, so VocalHire layers them. Each signal is weak on its own; together they give the hiring team a clear picture. Signals are indicators for a person to review — never proof, and never an automatic rejection.

1. Follow-ups that need real memories
The strongest weapon against ChatGPT answers. Polished but generic answers get "depth" follow-ups. If the main answer was great but the follow-up is suddenly weak, VocalHire flags "Struggled with follow-up detail".

2. Voice-only mode
In strict mode applicants must speak. Pasting AI text becomes impossible, and reading a script aloud shows up in the eye movement and timing checks.

3. Camera checks on the device
An on-device face model checks: is a face visible, is a second person there, are they looking away, do the eyes move like reading lines, and do the lips move when words are heard? **Images never leave the device** — only events like "looked away for 4 seconds".

4. Browser signals
Switching tabs, leaving the window, leaving full screen, pasting or trying to paste, copying the question, text appearing faster than anyone can type, a second screen, opening developer tools.

5. Answer-style signals
Answers that look AI-written (polished, generic, few real details), a long silence followed by a perfect answer, manipulation attempts, and hidden instructions in a CV.

6. Transparency
Applicants see exactly what is monitored before they start and must agree. Knowing the checks exist is the biggest deterrent of all.

The integrity score

Every interview starts at **100**. Each kind of signal takes off some points, up to a maximum for that kind, so one nervous glance never ruins anyone. The result is a level:

Score	Level	Effect
80–100	Clear	Nothing unusual.
55–79	Review	Worth a look. An AI recommendation of "Strong yes" is lowered to "Yes".
0–54	High risk	Several signals. The AI recommendation is at most "Lean no", and the team is told to check the timeline and transcript before deciding.

The three strictness levels (set per hiring interview)

Level	What it does
Off	Nothing is enforced. Used for practice interviews.
Standard	The default for hiring. Pasting is blocked; browser and answer signals are recorded; the camera is optional.
Strict	Camera required, full screen required, answers by voice only, pasting blocked. Each option can also be switched on or off on its own.

All 24 signal types, with their exact point values, are listed in `supabase/functions/_shared/integrity.ts`. The applicant sees a plain-language list before starting.

10. CV and job posting features

These work for both practice and hiring. The job posting can come from **anywhere** — a job board, the company's careers page, a recruiter's email, a PDF — not only LinkedIn.

Getting the documents in

- Upload PDF, Word (.docx), RTF or text files (up to 10 MB), or paste the text. Old .doc files are not supported.
- Files are read **inside the browser**. Only the text is sent, never the file.
- Scanned PDFs (photos of text) cannot be read — the person pastes the text instead.
- VocalHire turns them into short summaries: the **CV profile** (name, headline, years of experience, roles, skills, education, achievements) and the **job profile** (title, company, level, responsibilities, requirements, nice-to-haves, skills, keywords).

How the interview uses them

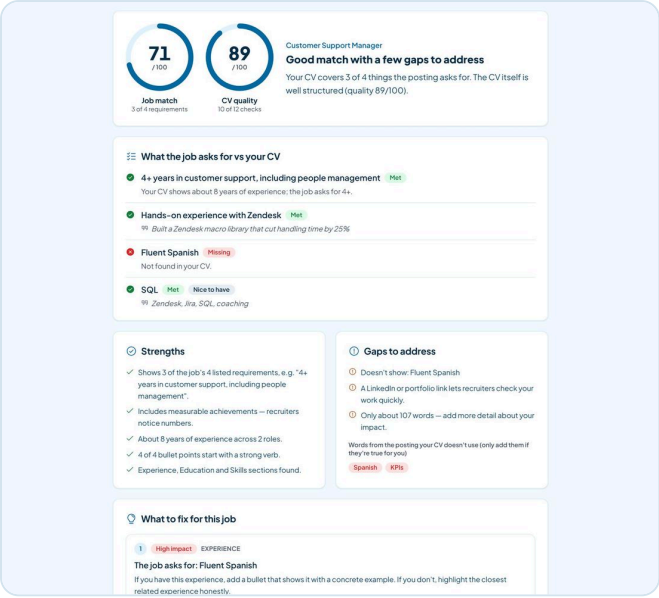
- The interviewer greets the person by first name.
- About every other main question is about a real item from the CV.
- The skills to test and the questions come from what the job asks for.
- The setup page fills in the role, company and level automatically.

CV review against a job

Available on its own page and from a practice report. The person gets:

- **Job match score** (0–100): how many requirements the CV shows — met, partly met or missing — each with the exact line from the CV as proof. Nice-to-haves count less than requirements.
- **CV quality score** (0–100) from about a dozen fixed checks: contact details, LinkedIn or portfolio link, length, measurable results, strong action verbs, no "I/my" in bullet points, short bullets, standard sections, a profile summary, dates for every role, no unnecessary personal details, and keywords from the posting.
- **What to fix for this job**, ordered by impact, with "now" and "try" rewrites. [Brackets] mark details only the person knows, like real numbers.
- Strengths, gaps, missing keywords ("only add them if they are true for you"), a profile summary written for this job, and what to be ready to talk about in the interview.

> **Honesty rules**
>
> VocalHire never invents experience. Proof must appear word-for-word in the CV, or the requirement is downgraded. Rewrites may only rephrase what is already there. Both scores are calculated by the server, not chosen by the AI.



A CV review: job match, CV quality, and requirement-by-requirement proof.

For hiring teams

- Choose per role: CV off, optional or required.
- A CV-versus-job fit summary is prepared for each applicant, with a "CV match" column in the ranking.
- The team can read the CV text next to the interview.
- Hidden instructions in a CV are removed and flagged as an integrity signal.

Saving money

Each document is read by the AI once and the summary is reused for 7 days. If the person changes their CV or pastes a different posting, it counts as a new document and is read again. For a hiring role, the posting is read once for all applicants.

11. The interviewer's voice

VocalHire has two ways to speak, and chooses automatically:

Voice	When it is used	Quality and cost
Browser voice	Always available. Used when natural voices are not set up, when someone picks a device voice, or when a natural line fails to load.	Free. Quality depends on the device — natural on some, robotic on older phones.
Natural voice (Amazon Polly)	Switches on automatically when you add AWS keys (Part 4).	Human-sounding and the same on every device. About 5–6¢ per interview with Neural voices.

- **10 natural voices:** Ruth (default), Matthew, Danielle, Stephen (American), Amy, Brian (British), Olivia (Australian), Kajal (Indian), Niamh (Irish) and Ayanda (South African).
- People practising choose a voice in the device check (it is remembered). Hiring teams choose one voice for all applicants of a role.
- **Neural engine by default**; the more human "generative" engine can be switched on with one setting (section 15 explains why Neural).
- Speed control and "captions only" work with both voices. "Repeat question" replays the audio already downloaded — no extra cost.
- **Never stuck:** if a natural line cannot be fetched or played, the browser voice says it instead.

- **Saving money:** lines that repeat across interviews (greetings, closings, the voice test) are stored as audio the second time they are used and reused after that. The text itself is not stored, and unused audio is deleted after 30 days.
- **Safe:** the voice service only speaks lines the server itself wrote for that interview, so nobody can use your AWS account to voice their own text.

> **Listening is separate from speaking**
>
> Turning the candidate's speech into text still uses the browser's free speech recognition. It works best in Chrome, Edge and Safari. In Firefox people type their answers. A future upgrade is Amazon Transcribe (Part 4).

12. Privacy and security in plain words

What VocalHire stores

- The transcript (questions and answers), scores, feedback and timing.
- For hiring: the applicant's name, email, CV text (if added) and integrity signals.
- Saved CV reviews.
- Secret links and IP addresses only in scrambled (hashed) form.

What it never stores

- No audio or video recordings.
- No camera images — face checks run on the person's device.
- No uploaded files — only the extracted text.
- For repeated voice lines: audio only, never the text.

Who can see what

- Practice interviews: only the person who did them.
- Hiring interviews: only that company's team.
- Applicants never see their score.
- One company can never see another company's data — this is enforced by the database itself (Row-Level Security).

Who processes data

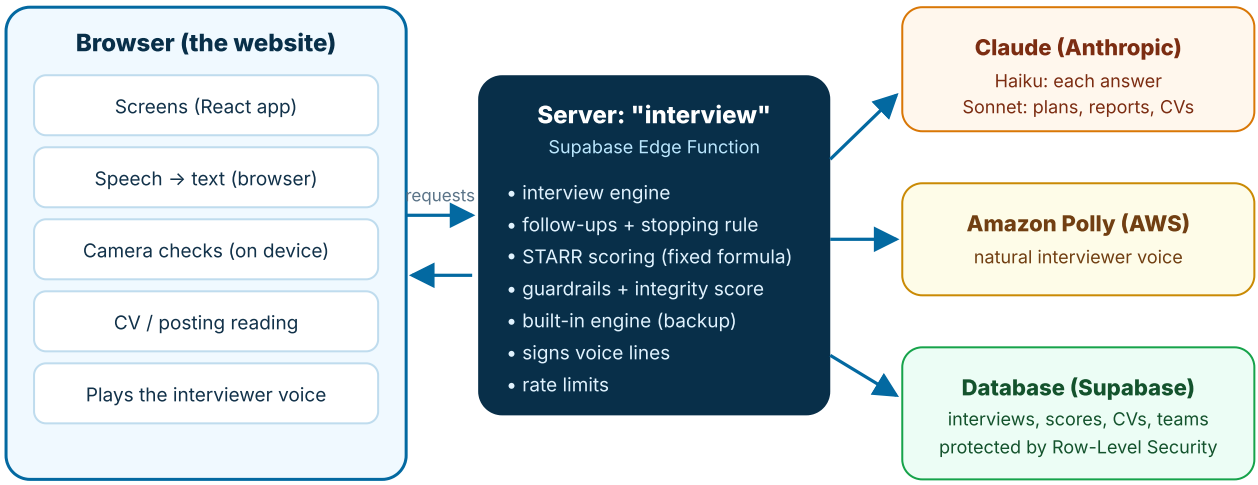
- **Supabase** (database, login, server) — EU region.
- **Anthropic** (Claude) — reads answers, CVs and postings to analyse them.
- **Amazon Web Services** (Polly) — receives only the interviewer's lines.
- **The browser's speech service** — in Chrome this is Google's service. VocalHire itself never receives audio.

Security measures

- All interview data is written by the server only. Nobody — not even a reviewer — can change a score.
- Guests and applicants use a secret link token; only its hash is stored.
- Database rules protect every table; internal tables are not reachable from the browser at all.
- Rate limits stop abuse and runaway costs (table below). 21 automatic API checks test these protections on every change.

Action	Limit	Action	Limit
Guest practice interviews	15 / hour per IP	Document reading	40 / hour
Signed-in practice interviews	30 / hour	CV reviews	10 guest / 25 user per hour
Applicants per role	25 / hour per IP	Voice lines per interview	300 / hour

13. How it is built



The three main pieces: the website in the browser, one server function, and the services it uses.

Piece	What it does	Technology
Website	All screens. Turns speech into text, runs the camera checks on the device, reads CV files, plays the voice.	React, TypeScript, Vite, Tailwind, MediaPipe
Server	One address with actions (start, answer, report, review CV, speak…). Runs the interview rules, scoring, guardrails and integrity scoring, and talks to Claude, Polly and the database.	Supabase Edge Function (Deno)
Database and login	Stores interviews, scores, teams, roles, CV reviews and caches. Handles accounts.	Supabase Postgres + Auth
AI	Reads answers, writes follow-ups and questions, writes reports, reads CVs and postings, reviews CVs.	Anthropic Claude (Haiku 5.5 + Sonnet 5.5)
Voice	Natural interviewer voice.	Amazon Polly (Neural)

The design follows the UI UX Pro Max design system: calm blue and green colours, large readable text, light and dark mode, and layouts that work on phones.

PART 2

Decisions we made, and why

The big choices behind VocalHire — so you can defend them when someone asks "why not X?"

14. AI models: why Claude Haiku + Sonnet

VocalHire uses two Claude models from Anthropic, each for the job it is best at:

Claude Haiku 5.5 — after every answer
Reads the answer, rates the STARR parts with quotes, and writes the follow-up or the next question. This runs about 12 times per interview, and in a voice conversation the reply must come fast. Haiku is the fastest and cheapest model.

Claude Sonnet 5.5 — the writing people read
Plans the interview, writes the final report, reads CVs and job postings, and writes the CV review. These run once or twice per interview, and quality shows here, so a stronger writer is worth it.

Model	Input, per million tokens	Output, per million tokens	Used for
Claude Haiku 5.5	$0.10	$0.50	Each answer (default)
Claude Sonnet 5.5	$2.00	$10.00	Plans, reports, documents, CV reviews (default)
Claude Opus 5.5	$4.00	$20.00	Optional — highest quality, highest cost

A "token" is a small piece of text (roughly ¾ of a word). Prices are Anthropic's published prices.

What one interview costs in AI

Measured from the real size of what the app sends (a standard interview of about 12 answers, with a CV and job posting):



A CV review costs about 7¢ with Sonnet (current setting). Real costs can be 20–30% higher or lower depending on length.

What stays the same on any model

The app itself decides the skills to test, the STARR rules and maths, when to ask follow-ups, when the interview ends, which CV item a question is about, the guardrails and the checks on every spoken line. So a cheaper model never makes the interview "basic".

What the model affects

How sharp the follow-ups are (picking up a specific detail), how precise the STARR ratings are, and how well the report and CV advice are written. That is why the reading-heavy parts use Sonnet.

Why Claude, and not another AI company?

We compared the cheapest capable models from other companies (prices from comparison websites, November 2026 — not confirmed on the official pages):

Model	Input / 1M	Output / 1M
Claude Haiku 5.5 (what we use)	$0.10	$0.50
OpenAI GPT-5 nano	about $0.05	about $0.40
Google Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite	about $0.10	about $0.40
DeepSeek V4.1 Flash	about $0.15–0.30	about $0.60–1.20
Mistral Small 4	about $0.15	about $0.60
xAI Grok 4.3	about $1.25	about $2.50

- **Same price band.** Haiku costs about the same as the cheapest models anywhere. Switching would save a fraction of a cent per interview.
- **The app is built on Claude features:** guaranteed structured answers (JSON), prompt caching, and automatic safety fallbacks. Switching means rewriting and re-testing the whole AI layer.
- **One supplier is simpler** for privacy contracts and support, and the built-in engine is already a backup if Claude is ever unavailable.

History: the first version used Claude Opus for everything (about 66¢ per interview). After measuring costs, it was changed to Haiku + Sonnet (about 10¢) with very little quality loss where it matters.

15. Voice: why Amazon Polly, not Nova Sonic, and why Neural

You asked about Amazon's "Sova" — the product is called **Amazon Nova Sonic**. Here is how the options compare:

Option	What it is	For VocalHire
Browser voice	The voice built into the visitor's browser.	Free, but quality depends on the device. Kept as the backup.

Option	What it is	For VocalHire
Amazon Polly	Turns text into speech. Claude writes the question, Polly reads it out.	**Chosen.** Fits the app as it is; cheap; simple.
Amazon Nova Sonic	A voice AI that listens, thinks and talks back itself, in real time — like a phone call.	More natural turn-taking, but it would take over the "thinking" part. Maybe later.
ElevenLabs	Text-to-speech with the most human-sounding voices.	Best quality, but the most expensive.
OpenAI / Google / Azure voices	Text-to-speech like Polly.	Similar quality and price; no reason to add another supplier.

Why Polly

- Claude and VocalHire's own rules stay in control: STARR scoring, follow-up rules, the confidence rule and every guardrail work exactly as designed.
- Every line is checked by the server before it is spoken.
- Cheap (about 5–6¢ per interview) and simple to run.
- Ten natural English accents; same voice on every device.

Why not Nova Sonic (for now)

- It would replace the listening and thinking parts, so keeping the scoring, guardrails and stopping rule in control would be much harder.
- It needs a constant live streaming connection — more complex to build and run.
- It costs more per interview.
- Good idea for later: an optional premium "live conversation" mode (Part 4).

Neural or Generative? We chose Neural.

		Generative
Price	$16 per million characters	$30 per million characters
Per interview (about 3,000–4,000 spoken characters)	**about 5–6¢**	about 10–12¢
Free allowance, first 12 months*	**1 million characters a month (about 250 interviews)**	100,000 characters a month (about 25 interviews)
Sound	Natural, clearly better than browser voices	The most human-sounding

*Free allowances come from comparison sites; confirm on the AWS pricing page.

The decision

Neural is half the price, has a much bigger free allowance and still sounds natural — the right choice while you are starting. It is the default in the code. When paying business customers justify it, switch to Generative by adding one setting: `VOCALHIRE_TTS_ENGINE = generative`.

Why not a realistic AI face that moves its lips?

Most users are nervous, and a realistic fake human can feel creepy and make them more anxious. Avatar services cost more per minute than the AI and voice together, add a delay before each question, and do not improve the scoring or feedback — the part people pay for. A cheaper idea for later is a friendly cartoon interviewer whose mouth moves with the Polly voice (Part 4).

16. Other important decisions

Decision	Why
A built-in engine as backup	The interview never gets stuck if the AI fails, and the app works (more simply) even without an AI key.
Scores calculated by code	Fair, consistent and impossible to talk into a better number.
A confidence rule, not a fixed length	Short when the result is clear, longer when it is borderline: respects time and is fairer.
Frozen skills per hiring role	Every applicant is measured on the same things, so the ranking is fair.
AI recommendation is advice only	People decide. This is also what privacy and AI laws expect for hiring (human oversight, no decisions made only by a machine).
Camera checks on the device, no recordings	Privacy and trust, lower legal risk, and no storage costs.
Signals, not verdicts	Nervous people look away; tabs switch by accident. Each signal is explained and a person decides.
Typing allowed in practice; voice-only only in strict hiring mode	Accessibility, and comfort for anxious users.
Pause and repeat buttons kept	Helpful for nervous users. A stricter "realistic mode" without them can be added later.
Guest mode for practice	People can try it without signing up; their history moves into the account later.
Files read in the browser	Privacy: only text is sent; no files are stored.
CV reviews never invent experience	Honesty and trust; fake CV claims hurt candidates and the product's reputation.
Reuse documents (7 days) and repeated voice lines	Lower costs without changing what anyone sees.
Signed voice lines	Nobody can use your AWS account to voice their own text.
Browser speech recognition for now	Free and good in Chrome, Edge and Safari. Amazon Transcribe is the upgrade if needed.
Supabase	Database, login, server functions and security rules in one place, with an EU region.

PART 3

Money

What VocalHire costs to run, and ideas for what to charge.

A note on numbers

Prices and costs in this guide were checked in November 2026. AI and cloud prices change often, and some numbers come from comparison websites rather than the official pages — those are marked "about". Always check the provider's own pricing page before you set your prices.

17. What it costs to run

Costs per use (once the AI and voice keys are added)

What	About	Notes
AI for one interview	10¢	Haiku after each answer + Sonnet for plan and report (with CV and posting).
Natural voice for one interview	5–6¢	Polly Neural. 10–12¢ with Generative. Free with the browser voice.
One CV review	7¢	Sonnet.
One interview with CV, AI + voice	**≈ 16¢**	Speech-to-text in the browser is free.

Example: one client does 5 interviews and 2 CV reviews

AI about $0.64 + voice about $0.30 = **about $0.94 in total**.

Fixed monthly costs (approximate — check each provider)

Service	About	Why you need it
Supabase Pro	$25 / month	No pausing when quiet, daily backups, more capacity. The free plan is fine for testing.
Website hosting	$0–20 / month	Netlify or Cloudflare Pages have free plans; Vercel's free plan is for non-commercial use only (Pro about $20).
Domain name	$10–20 / year	For example vocalhire.com or .app (if available).
Email service	$0–20 / month	Resend, Postmark or Amazon SES; free tiers cover the start.
Error monitoring	$0 to start	Sentry's free tier is enough at first.

Service	About	Why you need it
Payments (Stripe)	per sale	A small percentage + a fixed fee per card payment; depends on your country.

What it looks like as you grow (rough)

Interviews per month	AI + voice	Fixed (about)	Total (about)
100	$16	$50	$66
1,000	$160	$50	$210
10,000	$1,600	$100–200	$1,700–1,800

Keep costs under control

- Set a monthly spend limit in the Anthropic Console and a budget alert in AWS (Part 4).
- Rate limits are already built in, and documents and repeated voice lines are reused.
- When payments are added, each plan should have usage limits (for example interviews per month).

18. Pricing ideas

These are starting suggestions. Test them with real customers and look at competitors before deciding.

For job seekers

Plan	Idea	Your cost
Free	1 full interview + 1 CV review	≈ $0.23
Interview pack	about $9, one-off: 5 interviews + 2 CV reviews, for one job	≈ $0.94
Pro	about $12–15 / month: up to 30 interviews + 15 CV reviews	max ≈ $5.85

For businesses

Plan	Idea
Pay as you go	about $4–6 per completed interview (cost about 20¢ including CV fit)
Team	about $149 / month: 50 interviews, then about $3 each, 5 team members
Enterprise	Custom price: single sign-on, contract, data agreement, invoices, custom data retention

How to think about price

- **Price on value, not cost.** A job offer is worth a lot to a job seeker; a recruiter saves hours per hire.
- **Keep free use limited.** Each free interview costs you about 16¢, so require an account after the first one.
- **Remember the hidden costs:** payment fees, taxes (VAT), refunds, support and your own time.
- **Good channels:** university career centres, bootcamps and job clubs (they buy for many people at once), and small companies that hire often.

PART 4

Launch checklist

Everything still needed before and after you start selling — what, why, how, cost and effort. Tick the boxes as you go.

Suggested launch strategy

Launch the **job-seeker product (practice + CV review) first**. It has the lowest legal risk and you can start earning and learning quickly. Sell to **businesses** once the legal review (item 9) is done and a few pilot companies have tried it.

Priority	Meaning
Must	Do before you charge anyone.
Should	Do in the first weeks after launch.
Later	Future features that make the product bigger and better.

19. Must do before selling

☐ **1. Merge the work into the main branch** Must

Effort: 10 minutes · Cost: free · Who: you (or ask Claude Code)

Why: all the work is on the branch `claude/elegant-clarke-sn4oxl`. The main branch is what hosting services and other developers will use.

How: on GitHub open the repository → **Pull requests** → **New pull request** → base `main`, compare `claude/elegant-clarke-sn4oxl` → **Create** → **Merge**. Merging does not change the live server.

Note: the live server was deployed from the public GitHub code. If you make the repository private, future server deployments must use the Supabase command-line tool (Part 5).

☐ **2. Switch on Claude — add the Anthropic API key** Must

Effort: 10 minutes · Cost: about 10¢ per interview, prepaid credits · Who: you

Why: until then the live app uses the built-in rules engine. Claude gives much smarter follow-ups, scoring and reports.

1. Go to **console.anthropic.com**, sign up, open **Billing**, add a card and buy credits (start with $20–50).
2. Open **API Keys** → **Create key**, name it "vocalhire-production" and copy it (it starts with `sk-ant-`).
3. Go to **supabase.com/dashboard** → project `wujkhnnuptsijtyurnki` → **Edge Functions** → **Secrets** → add `ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` with the key → save.

4. Test: do a practice interview. The report should say it was analysed by Claude, not the built-in engine.

No other settings are needed: Haiku (each answer) and Sonnet (reports, CVs) are the defaults. New Anthropic accounts start with lower request limits that rise as you spend — fine for launch; ask for higher limits before onboarding a big customer.

3. Switch on natural voices — add AWS keys for Amazon Polly Must

Effort: 20 minutes · Cost: about 5–6¢ per interview (Neural), free allowance in year one · Who: you

Why: every user hears the same professional voice instead of their device's voice.

1. Create an account at **aws.amazon.com** (a card is required).
2. Open **IAM → Users → Create user**, name it `vocalhire-polly` (no console access needed).
3. Add an inline policy (JSON) that allows only speech:

```
{ "Version": "2012-10-17",
  "Statement": [{ "Effect": "Allow", "Action": "polly:SynthesizeSpeech", "Resource": "*" }] }
```

4. Open the user → **Security credentials → Create access key** ("application running outside AWS") and copy both values.
5. In Supabase **Edge Functions → Secrets** add `AWS_ACCESS_KEY_ID` and `AWS_SECRET_ACCESS_KEY`.
6. Test: start a practice interview — the device check now shows "Natural voices". Press "Test voice".

Neural is already the default. Never use your AWS "root" account keys — this user can do only one thing.

4. Set spending limits and alerts Must

Effort: 15 minutes · Cost: free · Who: you

Why: so a bug, abuse or sudden growth never surprises you with a big bill.

- **Anthropic Console:** set a monthly spend limit (for example $50 to start) and email alerts.
- **AWS:** Billing → **Budgets** → create a monthly cost budget (for example $20) with an email alert at 80%.
- **Supabase:** keep the spend cap on at first (Billing settings).

5. Put the website online with your own domain Must

Effort: about 1 hour · Cost: $0–20 / month + domain $10–20 / year · Who: you (Claude Code can help)

Why: the server and database are live, but the website itself is not online yet.

1. **Check the name.** Make sure "VocalHire" is free to use (a quick trademark search in your countries) and that a good domain is available.
2. Choose a host: **Netlify** or **Cloudflare Pages** (free plans), or **Vercel** (its free plan is non-commercial; Pro about $20/month). Setup files for Netlify and Vercel are already in the code.

3. Import the GitHub repository (branch `main`). Build command `npm run build`, output folder `dist` — the included files set this for you. No extra settings are needed: the app already points to the live Supabase project.
4. Add your domain in the host's domain settings and follow its DNS steps. HTTPS is automatic.
5. In Supabase → **Authentication → URL Configuration**: set the Site URL to your domain and add it to the redirect URLs.

☐ 6. Upgrade Supabase and check its settings Must

Effort: 20 minutes · Cost: about $25 / month · Who: you

Why: free projects pause when they are quiet and have no daily backups — not acceptable for paying customers.

- Billing → upgrade to **Pro** (daily backups, no pausing, more capacity).
- Authentication: turn email confirmation on (after item 7), and set password rules.
- Keep the EU region — helpful for GDPR.

☐ 7. Set up emails Must

Effort: 1–2 hours · Cost: free tier to start · Who: you (Claude Code can help)

Why: Supabase's built-in email only reaches your own team and is heavily limited, so real users would not get sign-up or password emails.

1. Choose an email provider (Resend, Postmark or Amazon SES) and verify your domain (it gives you DNS records to add).
2. Supabase → **Authentication → Emails → SMTP settings**: enter the provider's details and a sender like `no-reply@yourdomain.com`.
3. Edit the email templates (confirm sign-up, reset password) with VocalHire's name and colours.
4. Test sign-up and password reset end to end.

Emails for hiring (invitations, reminders, "a candidate finished") are a "Should" item in section 20.

☐ 8. Add payments with Stripe Must Needs building

Effort: 2–4 days of building and testing · Cost: Stripe fees per payment · Who: you + Claude Code

Why: there is no way to charge people yet.

What you do: create a Stripe account, verify your business, choose plans and prices (Part 3), and turn on Stripe Tax if you sell in many countries.

What gets built:

- A pricing page and Stripe Checkout for subscriptions and one-off packs.
- The Stripe customer portal (change card, cancel, invoices).
- A webhook on the server that records subscriptions and credits in the database.

- Limits: the server checks the plan before starting an interview or CV review and shows a friendly upgrade message.
- A usage page ("4 of 30 interviews used this month") and free-tier limits.

Everything is tested first in Stripe's test mode with fake cards.

9. Legal and compliance pack Must

Effort: depends on the lawyer · Cost: lawyer fees · Who: you + a lawyer who knows privacy and employment law

Why: hiring tools that use AI are regulated in many places, and you handle personal data (CVs, interview answers).

- **Terms of service** and a full **privacy policy** (expand the current privacy page). List every processor: Supabase, Anthropic, AWS, your email and payment providers, and mention that the browser's speech recognition (Google's service in Chrome) turns speech into text. Add a cookie notice if you add analytics.
- **GDPR** (EU/UK users): legal basis for processing, data processing agreements with Supabase, Anthropic and AWS (they offer standard ones), a list of sub-processors, how long data is kept, and how people can ask for deletion or a copy. For business customers you process data on their behalf, so offer them a data processing agreement too.
- **EU AI Act:** AI used to evaluate job candidates counts as "high-risk", which brings duties such as risk management, human oversight, record-keeping, transparency and documentation. Check the current dates and requirements with your lawyer.
- **No emotion recognition:** in the EU, AI that infers emotions at work is banned. VocalHire does not do this — keep it that way, and describe "delivery confidence" as pace and filler words, never emotions.
- **People decide:** under GDPR, hiring decisions should not be made only by a machine. VocalHire's recommendation is advice only — keep it that way and say so to customers.
- **USA examples:** New York City (bias audits and notices for automated hiring tools), Illinois (consent and explanation when AI analyses video interviews — relevant to the camera checks), Colorado (rules for high-risk AI decisions).

> **Important**
>
> This guide is not legal advice. It lists the topics to discuss with a lawyer before selling, especially to businesses.

10. Test with real people (a beta) Must

Effort: 1–2 weeks · Cost: small (AI and voice usage) · Who: you, testers, Claude Code for fixes

Why: 10–20 real people find problems no automatic test can — confusing wording, a phone that behaves differently, feedback that feels unfair.

- Invite 10–20 job seekers (friends, a university career centre) and 2–3 small companies for the hiring side.
- Test with Claude and Polly switched on, on iPhone (Safari), Android (Chrome), Windows (Edge/Chrome) and Mac (Safari/Chrome).

- Ask: was it realistic? Were the questions relevant? Was the feedback fair and useful? What was confusing?
- Watch the real cost per interview in the Anthropic and AWS dashboards.
- Fix what you find and tune the interviewer instructions if needed.

☐ **11. Error and uptime monitoring** Must

Effort: 1–2 hours · Cost: free tiers · Who: Claude Code + you

Why: you should know when something breaks before customers tell you.

- **Sentry** (free tier) catches website errors — a small code addition.
- Supabase dashboard → **Edge Functions → Logs** shows server errors.
- An uptime monitor (UptimeRobot or Better Stack, free tiers) checks the website every few minutes and emails you if it is down.

20. Should do soon after launch

Item	Why	Effort
Hiring emails build	Invite applicants by email, send reminders before a role closes, and tell the hiring team when a candidate finishes.	1–2 days
Admin dashboard for you build	See users, interviews per day, costs, revenue and abuse in one place.	1–2 days
Data retention and account deletion build	Delete old practice data automatically, let businesses set how long candidate data is kept, and let anyone delete their account. Needed for GDPR.	1 day
Help centre and feedback	An FAQ page, a support email, and a feedback button inside the app.	half a day
Privacy-friendly analytics	See where people drop off (for example Plausible or PostHog EU). Add a cookie notice if needed.	half a day
Accessibility check	Keyboard use, screen readers and contrast (WCAG 2.2 AA). The design already follows good rules — verify with a tool and a real user.	1 day
Fairness monitoring	Compare score patterns across groups and document bias testing. Needed for audits like New York City's, and builds trust with businesses.	ongoing
Security review	A penetration test before large business customers; two-factor login for business accounts.	1–2 weeks (external)
Capacity check	Test many interviews at the same time; raise Anthropic usage limits before big customers.	1 day
"Realistic mode" for practice	An optional mode without pause, repeat or coaching notes, for people who want a true test run.	half a day

Item	Why	Effort
Keep the README current	Small things, like the number of tests, are out of date in the README.	minutes

21. Future features

Ideas to grow the product after launch, with the reason for each. Build the ones customers ask for most.

Feature	What and why	Size
Cartoon interviewer with lip-sync	A friendly illustrated interviewer whose mouth moves with the voice. Amazon Polly can send mouth-shape timing (called visemes) with the audio, so no extra service is needed. Optional, with the calm animated circle kept as the default for anxious users.	Medium
"Live conversation" mode (Nova Sonic)	A premium mode that feels like a phone call, with natural interruptions. Needs careful design so scoring and guardrails stay in control.	Large
Amazon Transcribe for listening	More accurate speech-to-text that works in every browser (including Firefox) and keeps audio within your own cloud account.	Medium
More languages	Claude and Polly support many languages; the screens would need translating. Big opportunity outside English-speaking markets.	Medium
Mobile app	First an installable web app (works offline-friendly and has a home-screen icon), later native iPhone and Android apps.	Medium–Large
Integrations with hiring systems	Connect to applicant tracking systems (for example Greenhouse, Lever, Workable, Teamtailor, Personio) and offer an API and webhooks, so results flow into the tools companies already use.	Large
Team collaboration	Comments, shared scorecards, several reviewers per candidate, and calibration between reviewers.	Medium
Company question library	Companies add their own questions, values and scoring notes on top of VocalHire's rules.	Medium
Practice plans and reminders	Weekly goals, reminders, and extra practice on the person's weakest STARR part.	Small–Medium
Industry packs	Ready-made interview sets for nursing, sales, engineering, retail, graduates and more.	Small each
Technical and case interviews	New interview types (for example case studies or role plays) with their own scoring.	Large
Optional video recording	Some businesses want recordings. Only with clear consent; brings storage costs and more privacy duties.	Medium
White-label and single sign-on	Company branding on applicant pages, custom domains, and company login (SSO) for enterprise customers.	Medium
"Practise for this job" browser extension	One click on any job board page starts a practice interview with that posting.	Small–Medium
Profile import	Optionally import a profile (for example from LinkedIn) as well as any CV text.	Small
Realistic video avatar	Only if customers clearly ask for it (see section 15 for why not now).	Large

PART 5

How to work with it

Your handbook: where everything lives, every setting, how to test and ship changes, which file controls what, and what to do when something breaks.

22. Accounts, places and settings

Place	What lives there	Where
GitHub	All the code and its history.	`github.com/AlbanZ1/VocalHire_Remake`
Supabase	Database, login, the server function "interview", its secret settings and its logs.	Project `wujkhnnuptsijtyurnki` (EU, Ireland)
Anthropic Console	Claude API key, credits, usage and spend limits.	`console.anthropic.com`
AWS	The Polly user and its keys, budgets and billing.	`aws.amazon.com` (region `eu-central-1`)
Hosting to set up	The website.	Netlify, Cloudflare Pages or Vercel
Domain to set up	Your web address.	Any domain registrar
Stripe to set up	Payments, plans, invoices.	`stripe.com`
Email to set up	Sign-up and app emails.	Resend, Postmark or Amazon SES
Monitoring to set up	Error and uptime alerts.	Sentry, UptimeRobot or Better Stack

Server settings (Supabase → Edge Functions → Secrets)

These change how the live app behaves without changing any code. New interviews pick them up automatically.

Setting	Needed?	What it does	Default
`ANTHROPIC_API_KEY`	for Claude	Switches the AI on.	none → built-in engine
`VOCALHIRE_TURN_MODEL`	optional	Model used after each answer.	`claude-haiku-5-5`
`VOCALHIRE_MODEL`	optional	Model for plans, reports, documents and CV reviews.	`claude-sonnet-5-5`
`VOCALHIRE_TURN_EFFORT`	optional	How hard the AI thinks per answer: low, medium or high (higher = slower and costlier).	low
`VOCALHIRE_REPORT_EFFORT`	optional	Effort for the final report.	medium

Setting	Needed?	What it does	Default
`VOCALHIRE_REVIEW_EFFORT`	optional	Effort for CV reviews.	medium
`VOCALHIRE_DISABLE_FALLBACKS`	optional	Set to 1 to stop sending Claude's automatic safety fallbacks.	off
`AWS_ACCESS_KEY_ID` + `AWS_SECRET_ACCESS_KEY`	for voices	Switches natural voices (Polly) on.	none → browser voice
`VOCALHIRE_POLLY_REGION`	optional	AWS region used for Polly.	`eu-central-1`
`VOCALHIRE_TTS_ENGINE`	optional	`neural` or `generative`.	neural
`VOCALHIRE_TTS`	optional	Set to `off` to switch natural voices off without deleting the keys.	on
`VOCALHIRE_IP_SALT`	recommended	A long random secret used to scramble IP addresses for rate limits.	project address
`VOCALHIRE_RATE_LIMIT_MULTIPLIER`	testing only	Multiplies all rate limits (never use in production).	1

The website has optional settings too (`VITE_SUPABASE_URL`, `VITE_SUPABASE_PUBLISHABLE_KEY`, `VITE_INTERVIEW_FUNCTION`, `VITE_BASE_PATH`). The defaults already point to the live project, so you only need them if you move to another Supabase project.

Check what is switched on

Run this in a terminal (the key in it is a public key, safe to share):

```
curl -s -X POST https://wujkhnnuptsijtyurnki.supabase.co/functions/v1/interview \
  -H "content-type: application/json" \
  -H "apikey: sb_publishable_YyWpWmhmAyWf2aMKyXC5zQ_QKMpjNb3" \
  -H "authorization: Bearer sb_publishable_YyWpWmhmAyWf2aMKyXC5zQ_QKMpjNb3" \
  -d '{"action":"engine"}'
```

- `"engine":"claude"` with the two model names → Claude is on. `"heuristic"` → the built-in engine is in use.
- `"tts":{"provider":"polly","engine":"neural",…}` → natural voices are on. `"tts":null` → the browser voice is used.

23. Running, testing and shipping changes

What you need on a computer

Node.js 22, Git, and (for the full local copy) Docker. The Supabase command-line tool runs through `npx`, so it does not need a separate install.

Run the website on your computer

```
git clone https://github.com/AlbanZ1/VocalHire_Remake.git
cd VocalHire_Remake
npm install
npm run dev        # then open http://localhost:5173
```

> **Careful**
>
> This uses the **live** server and database. Accounts and interviews you create are real. For safe experiments, use the full local copy below.

Full local copy (a private sandbox)

```
npx supabase start                     # starts a local database and server (Docker)
npm run functions:bundle-local         # prepares the server code for local use
npx supabase functions serve --no-verify-jwt --env-file supabase/functions/.env
# in a second terminal (keys from "npx supabase status"):
VITE_SUPABASE_URL=http://127.0.0.1:54321 VITE_SUPABASE_PUBLISHABLE_KEY=<local key> \
VITE_INTERVIEW_FUNCTION=interview-local npm run dev
```

`supabase/functions/.env` is a private file (never committed). It can be empty, or hold test keys such as `ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` to try Claude locally.

The automatic tests

Command	What it checks
`npm test`	93 unit tests: scoring, guardrails, the built-in engine, the stopping rule, integrity, CV reading and review, AI model calls (against a fake API), AWS request signing and the voice code.
`FUNCTION=interview-local npm run smoke`	21 API and security checks against the local copy: secret links, blocked anonymous access, scores that cannot be edited, manipulation handling, company isolation, CV features and the voice endpoint.
`npm run e2e`	5 full browser tests: a practice interview, the whole hiring flow, CV review → tailored interview, and natural voice playback with fallback.
`npm run typecheck` and `npm run build`	The code has no type errors and the website builds.

On every push to GitHub, the included GitHub Actions workflow runs the type check, unit tests and build automatically.

Shipping a change, step by step

1. Make the change yourself, or describe it to Claude Code.
2. Run `npm test` (and the smoke and browser tests for bigger changes).
3. Commit and push to GitHub — directly to `main`, or on a branch with a pull request.
4. **Database change?** Add a file in `supabase/migrations/`, then run `npx supabase link --project-ref wujkhnnuptsijtyurnki` once and `npx supabase db push`.

5. **Server change?** Run `npx supabase login` once, then:

```
npx supabase functions deploy interview --no-verify-jwt --project-ref wujkhnnuptsijtyurnki
```

6. **Website change?** Once hosting is connected to GitHub, it rebuilds automatically when `main` changes.
7. Check: run the "engine" check and do one quick practice interview.

24. Where to change common things

I want to change…	File
STARR weights and score labels	`supabase/functions/_shared/rubric.ts`
The confidence rule (50–72, 70%, rounds of 2), length limits, follow-up rules	`supabase/functions/_shared/engine.ts`
Skills, built-in questions, greetings, closings	`supabase/functions/_shared/questionBank.ts`
What Claude is told (interviewer, planner, report, CV review)	`supabase/functions/_shared/prompts.ts`
Which Claude models and effort	Supabase secrets (no code); defaults in `supabase/functions/_shared/llm.ts`
Manipulation detection and spoken-line checks	`supabase/functions/_shared/guardrails.ts`
Integrity signals and their points	`supabase/functions/_shared/integrity.ts`
CV and posting reading, CV checks and review rules	`supabase/functions/_shared/documents.ts`
The list of voices and the voice-test sentence	`supabase/functions/_shared/voices.ts`
Rate limits, document reuse time (7 days)	`supabase/functions/interview/index.ts`
Practice lengths (Short / Standard / Thorough)	`src/pages/PracticeSetup.tsx`
Interview room (voice picker, captions, buttons)	`src/pages/InterviewRoom.tsx`
Hiring interview settings form	`src/pages/business/CampaignEditor.tsx`
Report page	`src/pages/Report.tsx` and `src/components/report/`
Landing page and privacy page text	`src/pages/Landing.tsx` , `src/pages/Privacy.tsx`
Colours and fonts	`src/index.css` (design rules in `design-system/vocalhire/`)
Database tables and security rules	`supabase/migrations/` (add a new file; never edit old ones)

25. When something goes wrong

You see…	Likely cause	What to do
Reports say "built-in engine"	No Anthropic key, a wrong key, or no credits.	Check the secret and your credits; look at the server logs.
No "Natural voices" in the device check	AWS keys missing or wrong, or `VOCALHIRE_TTS=off`.	Check the secrets. Server logs show lines starting with `[polly]`.
Some lines sound like a different voice	Those lines fell back to the browser voice (Polly error or timeout).	Check the logs and AWS limits. The interview keeps working either way.
Microphone does not work	Permission denied, or Firefox (no speech recognition).	Allow the microphone; use Chrome, Edge or Safari — or type.
"You've done this a lot in the last hour"	A rate limit.	Wait, or raise the limit in the server code if real users need more.
Sign-up emails never arrive	No email provider set up.	Checklist item 7.
Blank page or "404" after refreshing	Hosting not set up for a single-page app.	Use the included `netlify.toml` or `vercel.json`.
An applicant's link does not work	The role is closed, a draft, or past its closing date.	Check the role's status in the hiring dashboard.
Costs are higher than expected	Heavy use or abuse.	Check the Anthropic and AWS dashboards, lower limits, keep spend caps on.
The app stopped working after a quiet week	The free Supabase plan paused the project.	Restore it in the dashboard and upgrade to Pro (item 6).

Where to look

- **Supabase → Edge Functions → interview → Logs** — server errors.
- **Browser console** (press F12) — website errors.
- **Anthropic Console → Usage** — AI calls and cost.
- **AWS → Billing / Cost Explorer** — voice cost.

Working with Claude Code

- Describe the goal in plain words ("add Stripe payments with these plans").
- Ask it to run the tests and show you the result.
- It commits and pushes under your name only, on a branch.
- Review, then merge into `main` when you are happy.

PART 6

Explaining it to others

Ready-made words for customers, friends, investors and developers.

26. Pitches you can say out loud

One sentence

"VocalHire is an AI voice interviewer that listens to your answers, asks real follow-up questions, and scores your stories with the STARR method — for people practising and for companies screening applicants."

30 seconds — for job seekers

"Most people practise interviews in their head and then freeze. VocalHire lets you have a real spoken interview any time. Add your CV and the job you want, and the interviewer greets you by name, asks about your own experience and follows up when an answer is vague. Afterwards you see exactly which part of each story was missing, with quotes from what you said, and how to fix your CV for that job."

30 seconds — for companies

"Screening applicants takes hours and every interviewer asks different questions. With VocalHire you create one interview per role and share a link. Every applicant gets the same structured, adaptive interview — it digs deeper when answers are vague and spots AI-written answers. You get a ranked list with scores, evidence and transcripts. Your team still makes every decision."

Two minutes — for investors and partners

1. **Problem.** Interviews decide careers, but practice is rare and stressful, and companies screen inconsistently and slowly.
2. **Solution.** An AI interviewer you talk to. It analyses every answer before asking the next question, follows up on what is missing, and scores each story with STARR — with quoted evidence and a fixed formula.
3. **How it is different.** A real conversation instead of a quiz; personal questions from the CV and the actual job posting; a confidence rule that decides when it has seen enough; layered anti-cheating without recordings; built for nervous people.
4. **Business model.** Job seekers: a free first interview, then packs or a monthly plan. Companies: pay per interview or a monthly team plan. Each interview costs about 16 cents to run.
5. **Status.** The product is built and tested (practice, hiring, CV features, anti-cheating, natural voices). Next: payments, emails, legal review and a beta with real users.

27. Questions people will ask

Question	Answer
Can candidates cheat with ChatGPT?	It is hard. Follow-up questions ask for details only someone who lived the story knows. Strict mode needs spoken answers and a camera; pasting is blocked; reading from a screen and other people's voices are noticed. Everything is shown to the hiring team as explained signals.
Does the AI decide who gets hired?	No. It gives an advisory recommendation with evidence. People make every decision, and VocalHire never rejects anyone automatically.
Is the interview recorded?	No audio or video is stored. Camera checks run on the person's own device; only text events are saved.
How fair is the scoring?	Every applicant for a role gets the same skills and rules. Each score needs quotes from the answer, and the number comes from a fixed formula — not the AI's opinion.
Can someone talk the AI into a better score?	No. Manipulation attempts are detected, redirected and logged, and the AI never chooses the number.
How is it different from ChatGPT?	It is built for one job: a spoken interview with scoring rules, a stopping rule, anti-cheating, reports, CV review and hiring tools.
How is it different from one-way video interview tools?	It reacts to each answer with follow-ups, it records no video, and it shows STARR evidence instead of a black-box score.
Why not a human-looking avatar?	Many users are nervous, and realistic avatars can feel uncomfortable. They are also expensive and slow. A friendly cartoon interviewer is planned as an option.
Does it work on phones?	Yes, in modern browsers. Speaking works best in Chrome, Edge and Safari; people can always type instead.
What if the AI service goes down?	That step automatically uses VocalHire's built-in engine, so the interview continues.
Where is the data kept?	In a database in the EU (Ireland). Each company sees only its own candidates.
Which languages?	English today. The AI and voices support many languages, so others can be added.

28. Glossary

Word	Meaning
STARR	Situation, Task, Action, Result, Reflection — the five parts of a strong interview story.
Skill (competency)	What an interview question tests, for example "Problem solving" or "Customer focus". VocalHire has 18 built in.
Follow-up	An extra question about the same story, asked when something is missing or too generic.
Confidence rule	The rule that decides whether to ask more questions: unsure zone 50–72, or less than 70% evidence for a skill → two more questions.
Evidence	How sure VocalHire is about a skill (0–100%), growing with each good answer about it.
Integrity signal / score	A sign of possible cheating (like switching tabs), and the 0–100 score built from all signals.
Hiring interview (campaign)	One interview set up for one job, shared with applicants through one link.
Built-in engine	VocalHire's own rule-based interviewer, used when Claude is off or fails.
Claude Haiku / Sonnet / Opus	Anthropic's AI models: Haiku is the fastest and cheapest, Sonnet writes better, Opus is the strongest and costliest.
Token	A small piece of text (about ¾ of a word). AI prices are per million tokens.

Word	Meaning
Amazon Polly	Amazon's text-to-speech service, used for natural interviewer voices.
Neural / Generative	Two kinds of Polly voices. Neural: natural and cheaper (our default). Generative: most human, about twice the price.
Nova Sonic	Amazon's real-time voice AI that listens and talks back itself. Not used now; maybe later for a "live conversation" mode.
Viseme	The mouth shape for a sound. Polly can send these, which would let a cartoon interviewer move its lips.
Supabase	The platform that runs VocalHire's database, login and server function.
Edge Function	A small server program at Supabase. VocalHire's is called "interview".
Row-Level Security	Database rules that decide which rows each user may see — the reason one company can never see another's data.
Secret (setting)	A private value stored on the server, like an API key. Never put secrets in the code.
API key	A password that lets VocalHire use a service like Claude or Polly, and that is how they bill you.
Migration	A file that changes the database structure in a safe, recorded way.
Rate limit	A maximum number of actions per hour, to stop abuse and runaway costs.
CV profile / job profile	The short summaries VocalHire makes from a CV and a job posting.
Match score / quality score	In a CV review: how well the CV fits the job, and how well the CV is written.

Your next five steps

1. Merge the branch into `main` (item 1).
2. Add the Anthropic key and the AWS keys, and set spending alerts (items 2–4).
3. Put the website online with your domain, upgrade Supabase and set up emails (items 5–7).
4. Build payments with Claude Code, and book the legal review (items 8–9).
5. Run a beta with 10–20 real people, fix what they find, then launch (items 10–11).